

California's Big Gamble: Can a New Map Flip Congress?

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Picture a giant game of political chess. California just moved its pieces to try to win more seats in the U.S. House of Representatives. Why? Because Texas redrew its map to help Republicans, so California **Democrats** fought back. They got voters to let them draw new lines that could give them up to five extra seats. But there's a catch. In California's **primary**, the top two vote-getters move on, no matter their party. In a district near San Diego, a Republican seat was redrawn to lean slightly Democratic. The Republican congressman retired, so a local Republican supervisor, Jim Desmond, jumped in. But nineyes, nine! **Democrats** also want the job. If they split the vote too much, two Republicans could finish first and second, locking **Democrats** out of the November election entirely. "After millions of dollars and a nationwide effort to **redraw** these districts in response to Texas, **Democrats** being shut out would be a nightmare," said Ammar Campa-Najjar, one of the Democratic candidates. Other races are just as wild. In the Central Valley, a Republican who voted to **impeach** Trump faces two very different **Democrats** one backed by the party establishment, one a **progressive** professor. And in San Francisco, the race to replace Nancy Pelosi has a tech entrepreneur who helped Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez win. Tuesday's **primary** will show if California's big gamble pays off or backfires.

Word Treasure

primary -- A primary is an election where voters choose which candidates will compete in the bigger, final election.

impeach -- To impeach means to officially accuse a high official, like the president, of wrongdoing by the House of Representatives.

progressive -- Progressive describes a person or idea that wants big social changes and more government action to help people.

establishment -- In politics, the establishment is the group of people who have long been in power and control the party's direction.

redraw -- Redraw means to draw new boundary lines, especially for voting districts, to change which voters live where.

Democrats -- Democrats are members of one of the two main U.S. political parties, often supporting a bigger role for government in solving problems.

Background you need

California, the most populous U.S. state, has 52 seats in the House of Representatives, more than any other state, so its elections are closely watched.

Nancy Pelosi (the former Speaker of the House and a top Democrat) represented San Francisco for many years and is now leaving Congress, causing a rush to replace her.

Redistricting happens every ten years after the census, and sometimes parties redraw maps to give themselves an advantage--a practice called gerrymandering.

Break it down

WHO: California Democrats, Republican candidates like Jim Desmond, and Democratic candidates like Ammar Campa-Najjar

WHAT: California redrew its congressional maps to try to win more House seats, but the top-two primary system could accidentally lock Democrats out

WHERE: Multiple California districts, especially near San Diego, the Central Valley, and San Francisco

WHY: As a response to Texas redrawing its own map to help Republicans, Democrats want to flip enough seats to control Congress

Why it matters

Who gets elected to Congress can change laws about classroom technology, climate, and even how much homework you might have, so these primary results shape your future.

Test what you remember

1. Why did California redraw its district map?

- ☐ (A) To help Democrats gain House seats
- ☐ (B) To make all districts exactly equal
- ☐ (C) To reduce the number of districts
- ☐ (D) To help Republicans win more elections

2. In California's primary, how many candidates move on to the general election?

- ☐ (A) The top two, no matter their party
- ☐ (B) Only the winner from each party
- ☐ (C) Three candidates
- ☐ (D) All candidates are on the November ballot

3. Who is Jim Desmond?

- ☐ (A) A Democratic candidate
- ☐ (B) A Republican supervisor running for a seat near San Diego
- ☐ (C) The retiring congressman
- ☐ (D) The governor of California

4. What worry do some Democrats have in the San Diego-area district?

- ☐ (A) Too many Democrats could split votes and let two Republicans advance
- ☐ (B) Republicans will not show up to vote
- ☐ (C) Only one candidate is running
- ☐ (D) The district will be removed

5. Which candidate mentioned that Democrats being shut out would be a nightmare?

- ☐ (A) Nancy Pelosi
- ☐ (B) Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez
- ☐ (C) Ammar Campa-Najjar
- ☐ (D) Jim Desmond

6. In the Central Valley, what is notable about the Republican candidate?

- ☐ (A) He is a progressive professor
- ☐ (B) He voted to impeach Trump
- ☐ (C) He is a tech entrepreneur
- ☐ (D) He retired

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: A 3: B 4: A 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

1. **Democratic strategists (positive):** They see the map changes as a smart way to gain up to five seats and pass a Democratic agenda on climate, healthcare, and education.
2. **Local Republicans and critics (negative):** They point out that splitting the Democratic vote could backfire, leaving no Democrat on the November ballot and reducing competition.
3. **Nonpartisan analysts (neutral):** Many say redistricting is a normal power struggle between parties, but the top-two primary system adds an unpredictable twist rarely seen elsewhere.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):